

Incident handler's journal

Instructions

As you continue through this course, you may use this template to record your findings after completing an activity or to take notes on what you've learned about a specific tool or concept. You can also use this journal as a way to log the key takeaways about the different cybersecurity tools or concepts you encounter in this course.

Date: 25/07/2026	**Entry: #1**
Description	This entry documents a security incident involving a ransomware attack on a US clinic triggered by a phishing email
Tool(s) used	N/A
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • **Who** caused the incident? A group of unethical hackers • What happened? The attackers were able to gain access into the company's network by using targeted phishing emails, which were sent to several employees of the company • **When** did the incident occur? At 9:00 am on Tuesday • **Where** did the incident happen? A small US healthcare clinic • **Why** did the incident happen? The group of hackers are known to target small organizations in healthcare and transportation industries
Additional notes	Include any additional thoughts, questions, or findings. Employees should be trained to handle suspicious emails properly to mitigate any future phishing attacks

Date: 27/07/2026	**Entry: #2**
Description	Scanning a file to know if its malware or not
Tool(s) used	VirusTotal website
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • **Who** caused the incident? Threat actor • **What** happened? A suspicious file being downloaded on an employee's computer • **When** did the incident occur? During working office hours • **Where** did the incident happen? At the company • **Why** did the incident happen? The attachment was a password-protected spreadsheet file. The spreadsheet's password was provided in the email. The employee downloaded the file, then entered the password to open the file. When the employee opened the file, a malicious payload was then executed on their computer.
Additional notes	Include any additional thoughts, questions, or findings.

Date: 27/07/2026	**Entry: #3**
Description	Using a playbook to respond to a phishing incident
Tool(s) used	N/A
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • **Who** caused the incident? A suspicious attacker named Clyde West • **What** happened? A phishing attempt occurred where an attacker sent a fake job application email containing a password-protected malicious file (`bfsvc.exe`) • **When** did the incident occur? Wednesday, July 20, 2022, at 09:30:14 AM. • **Where** did the incident happen? Inergy's corporate email server • **Why** did the incident happen? The attacker initiated this phishing attack to trick HR personnel into downloading, decrypting, and executing a malicious executable (`.exe`) disguised as a resume and cover letter. The primary goal was to compromise the target endpoint, gain unauthorized access to the network, or deliver malware.
Additional notes	Include any additional thoughts, questions, or findings.

Date: 27/07/2026	**Entry: #4**
Description	Analyzing a final report post incident
Tool(s) used	N/A
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • **Who** caused the incident? An unauthorized user • **What** happened? an individual was able to gain unauthorized access to customer personal identifiable information (PII) and financial information. • **When** did the incident occur?3:13 p.m., PT, on December 22, 2022 • **Where** did the incident happen? The organization's e-commerce web application. • **Why** did the incident happen? A web application vulnerability allowed the attacker to perform a forced browsing attack by manipulating order numbers in the URL string of the purchase confirmation page to access and collect customer data.
Additional notes	Include any additional thoughts, questions, or findings.

Date: Record the date of the journal entry.	**Entry:** Record the journal entry number.
Description	Provide a brief description about the journal entry.
Tool(s) used	List any cybersecurity tools that were used.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • **Who** caused the incident? • **What** happened? • **When** did the incident occur? • **Where** did the incident happen? • **Why** did the incident happen?
Additional notes	Include any additional thoughts, questions, or findings.

Need another journal entry template?

If you want to add more journal entries, please copy one of the tables above and paste it into the template to use for future entries.

Reflections/Notes: Were there any specific activities that were challenging for you? Why or why not? The activities offered a good balance of challenge. Tasks like analyzing packet captures and parsing log files took a bit of practice to get right, but that hands-on problem-solving was the

best part of the course.

Has your understanding of incident detection and response changed since taking this course?
Yes, my understanding has expanded significantly. I now understand the structured lifecycle security teams use to detect and contain threats—such as applying the 5 W's during triage and using log analysis to trace an attack's root cause.

Was there a specific tool or concept that you enjoyed the most? Why?
Analyzing phishing attacks was the concept I enjoyed most. It gave me the opportunity to think like a security analyst—investigating suspicious headers, attachments, and domains to see how attackers manipulate users into compromising systems.